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Mahatma Gandhi Institute of
Education for Peace and
Sustainable Development

Skill 4: Self Compassion

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define self compassion
- Identify the different thinking traps and how they impact well being
- Recognize the importance of self compassion
- Examine if you practice self compassion
- Describe the three steps to cultivate compassion.
- Analyze how suffering and happiness depend on our thoughts and emotions rather than external situations
- Practice tools to develop greater self-compassion

What is Self-compassion

Self-compassion is about recognizing our own worth, understanding what truly makes us happy or unhappy, and finding ways to improve our well-being.

But it is always easy to be compassionate towards ourselves? Something that often gets in the way of practicing self compassion is thinking traps?

Thinking traps, or cognitive distortions, are ways our mind can trick us into believing things that aren't true. For example, you might think, "I'm not good enough" or "I always mess up," even when there's evidence that these thoughts aren't true. Our brain uses these thinking traps to protect us, but they often end up making us feel worse and block our path to true happiness.

To overcome these thinking traps, it's important to approach self-reflection with strength and resilience, so we can see past these distortions and focus on what will truly bring us happiness

and well-being. In the next section, we will discuss the common thinking traps and how we can move past them.

Thinking traps

Thinking traps are harmful mental states that twist how we see reality.

While our brain is designed to help us survive and thrive, it can sometimes make us see things incorrectly.

These distortions can affect how we feel, think, and even sense things around us.

Which of these lines do you think is longer?

<image 1>



<Image 2>



While many people might think the top line is longer, both these lines are the same length. Even if we measure these lines ourselves, the top line will still appear longer to us because it's a persistent perceptual distortion.

Thinking Trap 1: Hedonic Treadmill

The Hedonic Treadmill is a thinking trap where we keep chasing things like money, status, pleasure, and praise, but never feel fully satisfied. It's like running on a treadmill—you keep moving but never really get anywhere. For example, you might think, "If I just get that promotion, I'll be happy," but once you get it, you soon start wanting something else.

To step off the Hedonic Treadmill, it's important to practice realism, contentment, and appreciation. This doesn't mean you shouldn't aim for more in life, but it's about being aware of

what truly brings happiness and what doesn't. Work towards your goals, but also learn to appreciate what you have in the present moment.

For example, instead of always wanting the latest gadget, you can find contentment in the things you already own. By doing this, you can avoid the endless cycle of wanting more and more, which often leads to frustration rather than happiness.

Thinking Trap 2: Unrealistic Expectations

In our society, we often see the lives of the rich, famous, beautiful, and talented as the ultimate success. We are surrounded by images and stories of these “successful” people, making us believe that we need to be like them to be truly happy. This can make us chase after wealth, status, praise, and pleasure, while also fearing things like financial loss, insignificance, blame, and pain.

This belief that we need to live up to these high standards is a thinking trap called **Unrealistic Expectations**. It distorts our reality and often leads to disappointment and unhappiness. For example, you might think, “If I don’t have a lot of money or a perfect body, I won’t be happy.” But this kind of thinking only leads you towards more stress and suffering.

How to fix this?

We can start by examining our unrealistic expectations and understanding why we have them. For instance, ask yourself, “Why do I feel the need to be like these celebrities? What is really making me feel this way?” By shifting to a more caring and realistic view of yourself and others, you can focus on what truly matters, like your health, relationships, and personal growth.

We need to set goals without adding expectations that harm our well-being.

For example, instead of aiming to be like someone else, set goals that are meaningful to you and that align with your values. This helps you stay grounded and satisfied, rather than constantly chasing after something that might not even bring true happiness.

Unrealistic Expectations activity

Over the next one week, notice how you talk to yourself. Everytime you feel the pressure within yourself to achieve something, or to do something a certain way, ask yourself “is this an aspiration or an expectation” and note down how you feel. Alternatively, you can also use the following questions to reflect towards the end of the activity:

1. What are the sensations you felt in your body when you felt the pressure to achieve a certain goal?
2. Was that pressure external or internal?
3. Did you notice a shift when you reflected on whether your thought was an aspiration or an expectation?

Read each scenario below and decide whether it represents a realistic expectation (a goal that is achievable and considers your abilities and circumstances) or an unrealistic expectation (a goal that is too demanding or not achievable given the circumstances). Examine the following scenarios.

Scenarios:

1. You expect to learn a new language fluently in just one month without any prior experience.
2. You plan to save a small portion of your income each month to eventually buy a new laptop within a year.
3. You expect to never make mistakes at work, even though you're still learning the job.
4. You aim to improve your grades by dedicating an extra hour each day to study.
5. You expect to be in perfect physical shape after just one week of starting a new exercise routine.
6. You expect to balance a full-time job, school, and social life perfectly without ever feeling stressed or tired.
7. You plan to improve your public speaking skills by practicing in front of a small group of friends before presenting to a larger audience.

Types of Unrealistic Expectations

Superiority Bias

Superiority Bias Superiority Bias is when we think we are better, more unique, or overly optimistic about ourselves. This might seem harmless, but it can actually lead to problems like self-hatred or low self-esteem when reality doesn't match the way we view ourselves.

For example, you might think you're always right and others are wrong, but when things don't go your way, it can make you feel really down.

Inferiority Bias

Inferiority Bias happens when we underestimate our abilities or worth. This can make us set goals that are too hard to prove ourselves or set goals that are too easy because we don't believe we can do better.

For example, you might avoid trying new things because you're convinced you'll fail, or you might push yourself too hard, leading to burnout. Realistic expectations mean setting goals that are neither too high nor too low but match what we can realistically achieve.

Perfectionism

Perfectionism is when we expect ourselves (or others) to be perfect all the time. When we make even small mistakes, we judge ourselves harshly, leading to disappointment and frustration. It can also make us overly critical of others when they don't meet our unrealistic standards.

For example, if you expect to get perfect grades all the time, a single low mark can be very disappointing, even though it's a normal part of learning. Perfectionism can strain our relationships and make life more stressful.

In summary, having unrealistic expectations—whether thinking too highly or too poorly of ourselves—can lead to unnecessary stress and dissatisfaction. By recognizing these biases, we can work towards setting more balanced and achievable goals, improving our overall well-being and relationships.

Why is Self-compassion important?

Imagine you're having a tough day where everything feels overwhelming and stressful. What if, instead of letting the stress take over, you paused and thought about how you're feeling? Ask yourself: Is this feeling helping or hurting me? If it's hurting, what's causing it? Often, our thoughts and emotions come from a desire to avoid suffering and find happiness. But what's stopping us from being truly happy?

Sometimes, we mistakenly believe that material things or short-term pleasures will make us happy, but they only bring temporary satisfaction. Constantly chasing money, pleasure, praise, or status can actually make us feel worse, not better. Similarly, worrying too much about losing these things or feeling like you're not good enough can increase your stress and unhappiness. Unrealistic expectations can add pressure and make you feel bad about yourself when you don't meet them.

Ask yourself: Could your suffering be linked to expecting too much from yourself? Are you focusing too much on external things for happiness instead of looking inward?

Practicing self-compassion means realizing that you can change by understanding yourself better, developing new skills, and adopting positive attitudes. The goal of self-compassion is to build confidence in your ability to achieve lasting happiness, resilience, and inner peace. By being kinder and more compassionate to yourself, you lay the foundation to show more forgiveness, gratitude, empathy, and compassion to others.

Self-compassion is understanding your own worth, knowing what makes you happy or unhappy, and finding ways to improve your well-being.

Let us now see how compassionate we are to ourselves.

Do you practice Self-Compassion?

Write a letter to a friend activity

Write a letter to a friend who is going through a difficult time. In this letter, give your friend your support and include words of encouragement to help him/her through this difficult time.

Now, read this letter out aloud to yourself and reflect on the following questions:

1. How did that message make you feel?
2. Do you use similar words of encouragement and support when you are going through a difficult time? If not, why?

Three steps to Cultivate Compassion

Most of us find it easier to be compassionate towards others than ourselves. However, it is important to practice self-compassion for greater mental well-being. We know that we can't pour out of an empty cup, so, if we want to help others, we should first work on ourselves. How do we cultivate self-compassion? Here are three steps we can follow:

1. Remind yourself of that you have value regardless of your external circumstances
2. Understand and define what happiness means to you
3. Examine your way of thinking and acting and identify where you need to change.

Eight Worldly concerns

We all want to be happy, but the problem is with our understanding of what might bring us true happiness. For some of us it might be material wealth, while others might think a happy relationship or a new career might bring us lasting happiness, but does that really happen?

External sources do not lead to happiness because they are not permanent and not in our sole control. Instead, we need to shift our focus to internal qualities because they are under our control and can bring us genuine, lasting happiness.

One useful model for helping us think of the things we strive for and try to avoid that often lead to harmful mental states is the Eight Worldly Concerns. Our society often tells us that certain external things will bring happiness. Wealth, pleasure, praise or status are not inherently bad, and there is no harm in seeking them. While they definitely play a role in our happiness and well-being, what we need to determine is how much of a role they should play.

In the next section, we will discuss the eight worldly concerns and how they impact us.

Thinking Traps

Thinking Trap	Explanation
Status vs Insignificance	When we are too focused on these two worldly concerns, we want to be known as someone important and powerful and constantly strive for roles, positions, or titles that are considered valuable by society. Conversely, we fear losing that status and are afraid of not having an important role or being overlooked by our peers or society.
Financial loss vs Financial gain	When caught up in these two worldly concerns, we think money and material possessions will bring us lasting happiness but we constantly strive for bigger and better things, forgetting to be grateful for and enjoy what we have in that moment. On the other hand, fearing the loss of money or possessions can cause us to hoard them and feel disappointed or upset if we don't get or lose them.
Blame vs Praise	When we get caught by these two worldly concerns we seek people's compliments and approval of what we do or say and feel disappointed/ worthless when someone criticizes or disapproves of us, irrespective of

	whether there may be some truth to their criticism.
Pain vs Pleasure	When too focused on these two worldly concerns, we're constantly striving for pleasure through external means and moving from one thing to another without finding true happiness. Or, the fear of physical pain makes us constantly miserable. The more we focus on a source of real or potential pain, the more suffering it causes us.